"ECONOMIC GROWTH ALONE IS NOT OUR GOAL. WE WANT IT TO BE INCLUSIVE"

Looking self-assured and relaxed, **M.K. Stalin**, the 69-year-old chief minister of Tamil Nadu, spoke to Group Editorial Director **Raj Chengappa** at his private residence in state capital Chennai on his key priorities and his success mantra. Excerpts:



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Q. What is the secret of your success?
There is no secret. Being loyal to my people and acting according to my conscience are the reasons for my success. The people have made me what I am today. I am being true to them and working for their welfare. There was a time when people had to go and meet MLAs and ministers, but that has changed. Instead of them coming to us, even before we came to power, we went to every sector in Tamil Nadu in a plan called 'Namakku Naame' and directly met people and listened to their grievances. Then when I took over last year, I began the Ungal Thoguthiyil Muthalamaichar (CM in your constituency) and visited every constituency and listened to the issues people raised. We assured them that, one by one, we will solve all the problems raised. We are doing so now.

Q. What were your key priorities when you took over in May 2021, and what challenges did you face implementing them?
I became chief minister during a very challenging time. The pandemic was wreaking havoc. It was top priority. All my cabinet colleagues turned into Covid control ministers once we took charge. Even though the lockdown was an important means to control the spread of Covid-19, we made sure the livelihood of people was not affected and provided them with basic needs. We gave Rs 4,000 to all ration card holders in two instalments and distributed Corona relief kits with 13 grocery items. We implemented schemes like Illam Thedi Kalvi (Education at the Doorstep). Shortly after this, the state received record rainfall and many parts of the state were flooded. With active coordination and crisis management, it was handled effectively. Apart from the natural disasters we faced, the AIADMK regime from 2011 to 2021 was a man-made disaster. The first six years of the previous AIADMK regime were bad and the last four years worse. The administration was simply dysfunctional, corruption among ministers was rampant, and the fiscal position of Tamil Nadu was weakened. I took over in such a situation and have been bailing Tamil Nadu out of the mess created by them since. We are revitalising the state's economy with an economic advisory council that includes Nobel laureate Esther Duflo and former RBI governor Raghuram Rajan. We have leapfrogged from 14th position to 3rd in the ease of doing business rankings and were adjudged one of the top achievers. On the development front, the industries department is working in full swing; 207 MoUs have been signed since I took over, to bring in investments to the tune of Rs 2.23 lakh crore into the state.

Q. What is the Tamil Nadu model of development to fulfil your vision of the state becoming a trillion-dollar economy by 2030? What economic reforms are you instituting or have instituted?
Our target is to become a one trillion dollar economy by 2030 and we are